

AN ADVOCATE FOR MENTAL HEALTH

FOR NEERJA BIRLA, observation and realisation have played very important roles. For instance, as a parent, she did not miss the fact that many schools lacked the infrastructure and philosophy necessary for what she calls truly inclusive learning.

“It inspired me to establish our school divisions, with the goal of creating environments where holistic development is prioritised, enabling children to flourish,” she says. In a decade since, it is a matter of great pride to her that both Aditya Birla World Academy and The Aditya Birla International School have remained

true to their original vision. “They are not just institutions but places where students are driven by passion and empowered into well-rounded individuals.”

Over time, she has become a lot more aware about mental health. “Eight years ago, influenced by my own lived experiences and fuelled by the encouragement of my daughter Ananya, we established Mpower. This initiative aimed to make mental health resources accessible and affordable, marking a pivotal milestone in my professional life,” she says. Much as there is more awareness,



PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR

NEERJA BIRLA

52, Founder and Chairperson, Aditya Birla Education Trust

there is a lot more to be done on mental health. “It continues to rank relatively low on the list of priorities for substantial philanthropic funding, especially when compared to other health issues,” says Birla. The disparity in funding allocation is particularly evident in India, where

the mental health treatment gap is staggeringly high (it ranges from 70% to 92% due to barriers like stigma, insufficient professional resources, and high costs). However, there is greater focus on mental health after the pandemic. **BT**

— BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

ADVICE TO YOUNGER SELF

Be more authentic to yourself. Allow yourself to feel what you are truly feeling without masking it with societal norms

MANTRA FOR CHALLENGES

No situation will last forever; even the heaviest emotions will pass

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NEXT-GEN GODREJ

NYRIKA HOLKAR JOINED the family business in 2017. Today, the lawyer by training is one of the next-generation leaders being groomed to lead Godrej Enterprises Group (GEG), headed by her uncle Jamshyd N. Godrej. She is executing a comprehensive strategy to redefine and expand GEG’s furniture retail brand Interior. She is also driving a service transformation initiative across all of GEG’s consumer-facing businesses.

Holkar, who leads the brand, legal and M&A functions, successfully completed the family settlement agreement between different branches of the Godrej family by leading the strategy and negotiation efforts. She has also helped in significantly streamlining GEG’s financial exposure by instituting end-to-end processes for the management of commercial contracts, risk and IP. **BT**

— BY ARNAB DUTTA

WHY SHE MATTERS

After successfully completing the family settlement between different branches of the Godrej family, she is spearheading the group’s transformation initiative across all-consumer facing businesses



NYRIKA HOLKAR

42, Executive Director, Godrej Enterprises Group

PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE